RMU SAC: NFL DRAFT HACKATHON – FIRST ROUND FRENZY

I. The Scene

The 2026 NFL Draft is happening in Pittsburgh! You are a data scientist for a large sports memorabilia company in the heart of the Strip District in Pittsburgh, PA. With the Draft coming up and more foot traffic, your boss expects a large influx of sales. However, he is unsure what inventory he should order. He wants to sell college memorabilia of first-round talent, as he believes those players will sell better. He asks you to develop models projecting first-round talent. Because of this, you get to work, finding data on offensive prospects and their 2025 college football statistics.

II. The Task

In a **presentation (maximum of 10 minutes)**, please complete **all of the following**:

- Predict what NFL quarterback, wide receiver, and running back prospects will be drafted in the 1st round of this year's NFL Draft, based on historical data.
    - Explain model selection and reasoning, including confidence in predictions/strength of model
    - Describe limitations of the model → what excluded data could help with the predictions?
    - Make a suggestion to your boss of what players to target

III. The Data

You have access to 3 data sets (training sets) that contain a sample of college football quarterbacks, wide receivers, and running backs drafted from 2010 to 2024. You are also provided with three data sets (testing sets) consisting of the top prospects in each respective offensive position for this year's draft. **These** are the prospects you are predicting. You are welcome to use outside sources, but these sources should be cited in your presentation.
For more information on variables in the data, please see the **Data Dictionary.**

IV. Submission Requirements

- For this project, you have access to any statistical software (Excel, R, Python, SPSS, etc.)
- Make sure to properly annotate your code/document
- Presentation details
    - Title slide should have **ALL** team members names **AND** school affiliations
    - Max of a 10-min screen recording of your presentation
    - Works Cited (if used outside sources or research)
- Email your code file, presentation slide deck, and screen recorded presentation in a **ZIP file** to lasst200@mail.rmu.edu.

V. Team and Ethical Guidelines

- Must be an undergraduate or graduate student at an accredited university
- 1 - 4 members per team
- Professors may advise but not directly contribute to the project
    - Any blatant plagiarism or cheating will result in automatic disqualification

VI. Timeline

- **Registration Due**: Sunday, April 12, 2026 at midnight
- **Project Start and Prompt Release:** Monday, April 13, 2026
- **Project Due:** Wednesday, April 22, 2026 at midnight

VII. Judges' Criteria

- **Completion of Task (10 points)**:
    - Did you provide sound predictions for first-round talents?
    - Did you provide limitations of the model?
    - Did you give a suggestion for what players to target?
- **Modeling (20 points):**
    - Did you provide reasoning and justification for model selection?
    - Did you discuss the strength of your model? How confident can we be?
- **Interpretability (15 points)**:
    - Did you provide clear, actionable insights for your owner, with backed reasoning?
    - Did you explain why you selected the variables and their importance in your model?
- **Communication (15 points)**:
    - How clear are you at communicating your results? Are you providing suggestions based on statistical modeling?
    - Are visuals helpful in understanding your process?
- **Execution (10 points):**
    - Did you submit a recorded presentation that is 10 minutes or less?
    - Is the presentation professional and clean (formatted visuals, no spelling errors that take away meaning, etc.)? Would you show this to your boss?

VIII. Awards

- **1st place:** Will receive $200 in Amazon gift cards
- **2nd place:** Will receive $100 in Amazon gift cards

Questions? Email lasst200@mail.rmu.edu